The 6:15

THURSDAY · OCTOBER 22, 2026 NO. 28

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Today	Weekly initial jobless claims, 8:30a ET — last clean data point before the FOMC.
Fri 10/23	World Series Game 1, Rays at Brewers, American Family Field, Milwaukee (8p ET, Fox); Knicks at Boston Celtics.
Sat 10/24	Northwestern hosts Rutgers, Ryan Field.
Tue-Wed 10/27-28	FOMC meets. Cut odds thin, 15%-24% across venues, unchanged from issue No. 27; July's meeting held 9-3, all three dissents for a *hike*, not a cut — a hawkish committee walking into a week oil just spiked.
Thu 10/29	PCE (Sept. data) and the Q3 GDP advance estimate, both 8:30a ET — date newly confirmed this run, resolving issue No. 27's open flag.
Sun 11/1	OPEC+ meets.
Tue 11/3	Midterm elections.

Coca-Cola, Boeing and GE Vernova appear on a UK-brokerage earnings tracker (forex.com) for Oct. 27-28; neither Nasdaq's nor CNBC's own calendar verified this run — **not verified this run**. No frontier-AI release, rocket launch or VC mega-round cleared verification this run — seventh straight issue skipping that sub-bullet.

METRICS · ~6:10A ET UNLESS NOTED; NO ICE/NYMEX SETTLE YET PRE-NY-OPEN

Oil	Brent $111.62 (+2.57%, Yahoo BZ=F, 6:08a) / $111.95 (+1.63%, straits.live, 5:15a) — both feeds now agree on direction, unlike yesterday's split. WTI $99.26 (+2.17%, Yahoo CL=F Dec., 6:07a); spread ~$12.36, wider than Tue.'s ~$10.82.
Rates/$	2Y 4.81% / 10Y 5.13% / 30Y 5.42% (Treasury.gov, Wed. 10/21 close); DXY 101.47 (-0.13%, 6:19a).
Equities/vol	S&P futures (ES, Dec.) 7,720.25 (-1.03%); Nasdaq 100 futures (NQ, Dec.) 29,483.50 (-1.74%), both

	~6:08a; VIX 18.50 (+10.91%, 6:02a).
Gold/gas	Gold (Dec.) $4,102.37 (-1.15%, 6:03a) — **down, not up, on a risk-off morning**, unreconciled. AAA national retail gas $4.2701/gal today, up from $4.2644 on 10/21 — first daily rise after a run of declines.
Asia (close)	Nikkei 225 63,070.00 (-2.40%); Hang Seng 22,934.68 (-3.03%); Shanghai Composite 3,658.03 (-1.48%). China's CSI 300 separately reported down 20% from its June peak — a bear-market threshold (Coindesk).
Europe (mid-session)	FTSE 100 10,703.97 (-0.45%); DAX 25,351.85 (-1.14%); CAC 40 7,809.05 (-1.42%), all ~6:20a ET / ~11:20a local.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Status	Closed to commercial shipping, straits.live, Day 235 **(single-sourced framing, continuity)**.
Transits	Still 4 vessels on Oct. 18 (IMF PortWatch) vs. 85/day baseline — the same stale reading carried in issue No. 27; PortWatch hasn't updated in four days.
Strikes, 24h (claimed)	Iran's IRGC says seven vessels hit — four set ablaze mid-transfer in the north-central Gulf, three disabled by mines west of the strait — Tehran's largest single-day tally of the crisis; no vessel names, flags or casualties supplied **[NEW, unverified]**. UKMTO separately confirms a tanker hit by an unidentified projectile 30nm SE of Al Faw, Iraq, Tue. evening — no injuries, no damage reported **[NEW]**. US military disputes Tehran's mine claims specifically, saying lanes are clear and missiles/drones, not mines, are responsible **[NEW]**.
Dark tankers	77 of 149 screened went AIS-dark, 24h (51.7%) vs. a 7-day average of 98.5 — a higher dark-rate than issue No. 27's 33.1%/97.0 **[DEVELOPING]**. VLCC war-risk premium still ~$10.0m/passage, ~32x pre-crisis — dated Jul. 27, stale, background only.
Cumulative	IMO: 119 confirmed maritime-security incidents across the wider Middle East since hostilities

	began, 24 seafarer deaths **[NEW]** — a different population and start point than UKMTO/Seatrade's 153-since-March-1 figure in issue No. 27; not comparable, not reconciled. Crisis Pressure 88±8 (Extreme, flat); Escalation Forecast 61±12 (High, +1), both straits.live.
Market odds	Polymarket still prices normal transit by Oct. 31 at 1%, unchanged — single-sourced to straits.live's aggregation.

Methodology: PortWatch (lagged strait transit count), UKMTO (incident reports over a wider maritime area), IMO (regional cumulative tally since the war's outset) and straits.live's AIS snapshot measure different populations over different windows — never averaged or differenced here.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Season over — eliminated Oct. 7, swept 3-0 by Tampa Bay.
Knicks	0-1 after the Oct. 20 home loss to Philadelphia; at Boston Celtics Fri. 10/23 — no game since issue No. 27.
Northwestern	5-1; hosts Rutgers Oct. 24.

LEAD

HORMUZ / MARKETS

Iran claims its biggest wave of Hormuz hits yet; oil jumps, stocks sell off worldwide into a hawkish Fed week

Iran's Revolutionary Guards navy said Thursday that its forces hit seven vessels across the Persian Gulf in the prior 24 hours — the largest single-day tally Tehran has claimed since the crisis began in February. Four vessels, which the IRGC said were using a route it considers unauthorized for ship-to-ship oil transfers, were struck simultaneously in the north-central Gulf after being tracked overnight and were left burning; three more, west of the Strait of Hormuz, reportedly hit naval mines and were disabled. [fact, NEW,

IRGC via Reuters] Tehran supplied no vessel names, flags, casualty figures or independently verifiable evidence for any of the seven, and the claim should be read as Iranian wartime messaging, not a confirmed incident count. [fact/flag] The US military separately disputed the mine portion of the claim specifically, saying shipping lanes have been cleared and that missiles and drones, not mines, are responsible for the attacks on commercial vessels it has tracked. [fact, NEW] What UKMTO itself confirms is narrower: a tanker hit by an unidentified projectile 30 nautical miles southeast of Iraq's Al Faw on Tuesday evening, with no injuries or damage reported by its master. [fact, NEW] Tehran, for its part, warned Washington that continued attempts to move vessels through routes it deems prohibited could draw attacks on US military bases across the region — a wider-response threat this brief has not seen stated so explicitly before. [fact/flag, NEW]

Markets reacted to the claim, not to any independent confirmation of it, and reacted hard. Brent and WTI both jumped more than 2% intraday, with Yahoo's BZ=F near $111.62 and straits.live's own feed near $111.95 as of this morning — the two quote sources this brief tracks now agree on direction after yesterday's split, resolving that flag from issue No. 27, even as they still differ on magnitude. [fact] Asia closed broadly lower: the Nikkei down 2.40% to 63,070.00, the Hang Seng down 3.03% to 22,934.68, the Shanghai Composite down 1.48% to 3,658.03, with China's CSI 300 separately reported 20% below its June peak — a bear-market threshold for that benchmark. [fact] Europe was following lower at midday, and US index futures pointed to a rough open: S&P futures down 1.03%, Nasdaq 100 futures down 1.74%, with the VIX up nearly 11% to 18.50. [fact] Bitcoin gave up a push above $84,000 and was retreating toward

$82,000 in the same window — a cross-asset risk-off move, not an oil-complex-only one. [fact/read] One genuine oddity: gold fell 1.15% to $4,102.37 even as everything else around it sold off, the kind of mixed signal this brief flags rather than smooths over; it may reflect dollar positioning or margin-driven liquidation across correlated longs rather than any read on the Hormuz claim itself, but no single source confirms either explanation. [read/flag]

The selloff wasn't only about Hormuz. Coindesk and other outlets tied part of Asia's tech-sector weakness to mixed US earnings unsettling AI-spending expectations: Tesla fell roughly 2%-3% after hours Wednesday despite beating on adjusted EPS ($0.48 vs. ~$0.44-0.45 consensus), after cutting its 2026 capital-spending guidance to roughly $20 billion and reporting operating income down 56% to $718 million, while Meta moved the other way, raising the low end of its own spending guidance the same week. [fact, NEW] That divergence — one AI-capex bellwether pulling back as another leans in — is itself feeding the market's unease about whether the spending boom is being underwritten by demand or by momentum, a question this brief will keep separate from the Hormuz-driven oil move rather than conflating the two. [read]

The timing compounds the stakes for next week. The FOMC meets Oct. 27-28 with cut odds already thin — 15%-24% across the venues this brief tracks, unchanged from issue No. 27 — and a committee that held 9-3 in July with all three dissents arguing for a *hike*, not a cut. [fact/flag, continuity + NEW context] A crude spike that holds into the October inflation-reference period would hand that committee a hotter energy pass-through just as it weighs easing, reinforcing rather than undercutting the thin-odds read. [read] Thursday's 8:30a ET jobless claims print is now the last clean

domestic data point before the meeting; PCE and the Q3 GDP advance estimate both land Oct. 29, the day after the decision — a date this brief can newly confirm, closing the gap flagged in issue No. 27. [fact, NEW] The claim also lands eleven days before midterms and ten days before OPEC+'s Nov. 1 meeting, which already held November output flat at 31.01m bpd on Oct. 4; a sustained spike into that meeting raises the political cost of holding output steady again, though no OPEC+ delegate has signaled a change in response to this week's claims. [read] This brief is deliberately not re-running the approval and generic-ballot numbers carried in issue No. 27 — nothing in them moved overnight — but the broader point stands: a wartime escalation claim landing this close to an election, on a day the market is already pricing in an energy-driven inflation risk, raises the bar for whatever the administration says next, whether or not Thursday's attacks are ever independently confirmed. [read] Watch: whether any government, carrier or insurer independently corroborates any of Iran's seven claimed hits; whether Brent holds above $110 through the NY open and settle; Thursday's claims number as the next read on how much room the Fed actually has; and whether OPEC+ signals anything before Nov. 1.

ECONOMICS

Thursday's 8:30a ET initial jobless claims are the only US data due before the Fed meets, and the setup around that meeting sharpened overnight rather than changed direction: cut odds remain thin (15%-24%, continuity), and this brief can now report that July's FOMC held 3.50%-3.75% on a 9-3 vote in which every dissent favored a hike, not a cut — a detail not previously carried here and a reminder the committee's tilt was hawkish even before this morning's

oil spike. [fact, NEW] PCE for September and the Q3 GDP advance estimate both land Oct. 29, the morning after the decision — newly confirmed this run against issue No. 27's open flag. [fact, NEW] The read, elaborated in the Lead: a crude spike holding into the October CPI reference window would complicate any dovish case regardless of what claims shows Thursday. [read]

BUSINESS

Tesla's actual Q3 print (previewed in issue No. 27, detailed partly in the Lead): adjusted EPS of $0.48 beat a consensus near $0.44-$0.45, but revenue was essentially flat year over year near $28.05bn, GAAP net income attributable to shareholders fell 43% to $787 million, and operating income dropped 56% to $718 million on higher opex. [fact, NEW] The offsets: automotive gross margin excluding credits rose to 18.1% from 16.3% in Q2, and free cash flow swung to positive $1.53bn against a forecast burn closer to $4.5bn. [fact, NEW] Management cut 2026 capex guidance to roughly $20bn, and commentary pointed to a slower Optimus timeline with no new detail on any SpaceX-merger speculation. [fact/flag, NEW] Shares, up 3.41% in the regular session on the delivery beat, gave most of that back after hours, down in a 2%-3% range depending on the source — a now-familiar pattern for this stock, which also fell after beating on Q1 and Q2 prints earlier this year. [fact/flag, differs by source] Netflix's Q3 (detailed fully in issue No. 27 — EPS beat, 2026 ad-revenue guidance cut to $2.7bn from $3bn, shares down roughly 6% after hours) is not re-carried here; nothing in it moved further overnight. [continuity] Separately, Coca-Cola, Boeing and GE Vernova appear dated Oct. 27-28 on a UK-brokerage tracker (forex.com); this brief could not verify any of the three against

Nasdaq's or CNBC's own calendar this run, so treat the dates as **not verified this run**. [fact/flag]

TECHNOLOGY

The sector's overnight story is a capex divergence, not a product one: Tesla cut 2026 capital spending guidance to roughly $20bn the same week Meta raised the low end of its own spending range, and Asian markets read the contrast as fresh uncertainty about whether AI-linked capital spending is being driven by demand or by momentum. [fact/read, NEW] Coindesk tied part of Thursday's tech-led Asia selloff directly to that unease, alongside the oil-driven risk-off detailed in the Lead. [fact, NEW] Bitcoin's slide from above $84,000 toward $82,000 in the same window tracks the broader cross-asset de-risking rather than any crypto-specific news. [fact/read] Nothing else moved: no frontier-model release, rocket launch or VC mega-round cleared this run's verification bar — the seventh consecutive issue without one.

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the seven-vessel claim and its market effect (Lead), two things are additive here. First, a precision the IMO supplies for the first time in this brief: 119 confirmed maritime-security incidents across the wider Middle East since hostilities began, with 24 seafarer deaths. [fact, NEW] That figure is not comparable to UKMTO/Seatrade's 153-incidents-since-March-1 count carried in issue No. 27 — different geography (regional vs. strait-specific) and a different start date — and this brief is not attempting to reconcile the two, consistent with the methodology rule applied throughout. Second, the dark-tanker rate worsened: 77 of 149 screened vessels

went AIS-dark in the last 24 hours (51.7%) against a 7-day average of 98.5, up from the 33.1% rate and 97.0 average logged in issue No. 27 — more tankers obscuring their position even as the IRGC claims an expanded campaign. [fact, DEVELOPING] Diplomatically, nothing has moved since issue No. 26/27: no October reporting surfaced on Araghchi's seven-day reopening offer or any US response to it, so that thread stays carried as unresolved rather than re-dated as news. [fact/flag, continuity] Crisis Pressure holds at 88±8 (Extreme); the Escalation Forecast ticked up one point to 61±12 (High) — both straits.live, methodology not independently checked. One more data point from that same aggregator, carried here for the first time: Tehran's open-market exchange rate was quoted at 271,725 toman per US dollar as of this morning, a currency-pressure gauge this brief will start tracking issue to issue now that a figure exists, rather than treating the rial's informal rate as unmeasurable. [fact, NEW, single-sourced]

SPORTS

Yankees	Season over; eliminated Oct. 7, swept 3-0 by Tampa Bay in the ALDS.
Knicks	0-1; lost the opener 106-100 to Philadelphia at home Oct. 20; next at Boston Celtics Fri. 10/23.
Northwestern	5-1; hosts Rutgers Sat. 10/24, Ryan Field.
World Series	Rays (AL champions) open at the Brewers (103-59, best record in baseball) Fri. 10/23, 8p ET, Fox — Game 1 of the first Fall Classic since 1980 between two franchises that have never won a title.

Continuity. Politics is cut this issue — the five approval polls and generic-ballot figures carried in issue No. 27 (Pew 30%, Reuters/Ipsos 32%, ABC/Post/Ipsos 33%, YouGov 34%, Fox 36%) are unchanged overnight, so this brief isn't re-adjectiving a stale read rather than reporting news. Geopolitics (Russia-Ukraine) stays cut — nothing dated past the single-sourced Oct. 11 energy-truce claim surfaced this run. Araghchi's Hormuz reopening offer remains an open diplomatic thread with no October update found.

Unverified figures are marked in red: both Brent feeds (direction now agreed, magnitude still not); IRGC's seven-vessel claim in full; Coca-Cola/Boeing/GE Vernova's earnings dates; gold falling on a risk-off morning, unreconciled. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.